

from home and reduce my outgoings considerably, paying off any and all remaining balances.

‘I still live with my parents, but I now have a plan to own my own home. I have a PowerPoint presentation and everything.’

Charlotte’s story can be typical of how our experiences with money can shape our attitude and behaviour with it, and how difficult those cycles can be to break – but it is also an example of what’s possible once you start to understand and process those behaviours.

Important to note: The role of money in relationships can be as simple as having different attitudes to spending and saving, but it can also wander into the realms of financial abuse, which the organisation Women’s Aid defines as ‘[abuse which] involves a perpetrator using or misusing money which limits and controls their partner’s current and future actions and their freedom of choice. It can include using credit cards without permission, putting contractual obligations in their partner’s name, and gambling with family assets.’³ The lines when it comes to financial abuse can be blurry, and it can feel difficult to define, but it’s important to address any behaviour that might be moving into this territory, because control of resources, including money, can be a barrier to leaving a relationship that is abusive in other ways too.

Laura* has a similarly complex relationship with money, this time stemming from feeling financially insecure as a child.